



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Bethel Classical Academy
School Website: <https://bethelclassical.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Hillsdale Academy (<https://academy.hillsdale.edu>) presents clear, repeated evidence of a classical Christian school across all six essential elements. Its public materials explicitly affirm objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty; a mission of formation in virtue and wisdom; a traditional liberal arts curriculum including Latin, logic, and rhetoric; upper□school Socratic dialogue and capstone defenses; faculty who model and mentor toward virtue; and a robust parent partnership and liturgical life. These features align tightly with the positive indicators in the "Six Essential Elements of a Classical School" keyword framework and the supporting lexicon used for this audit .

School website used: <https://academy.hillsdale.edu>

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - "An approach to instruction that acknowledges objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty"
 - "Christian institution ... religious instruction ... opening ceremony includes the Lord's Prayer ... corporate prayer ... weekly chapel service"
 - Teachers as "spiritual mentors ... explore how the greatest minds, from St. Augustine to C. S. Lewis, understood Christianity"
 - Mission/identity language: "private classical Christian school," "honors and esteems its Maker"
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; moral realism/objective reality; theology; faith and reason; chapel/liturgy; communal prayer; sacred tradition .
 - Negative indicators (e.g., values□neutral, secular humanism) not present .
- Quantitative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: +12 (truth, goodness, beauty, Christian, religious instruction, chapel, Lord's Prayer, corporate prayer, spiritual mentors, St. Augustine, Maker, communal worship); Negative hits: -0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage (3/3 sub□criteria: moral realism, theology, liturgical life): 100%
- Category rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - "Rooted in tradition. Pursuing truth. Cultivating virtue and wisdom." (hero)

- “Strives to cultivate Christian classical virtue and wisdom and to nurture the child’s humanity—mind, body, and spirit”
- “Education is about more than just preparing for college or getting a good job ... cultivating students into a certain kind of human being ... love the right things ... characterized by virtue and wisdom”
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos (true/good/beautiful), cultivation of humanity .
 - Negative indicators (e.g., “college and career ready” as primary aim) are explicitly contrasted and not foregrounded .
- Quantitative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: +6; Negative hits: –0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage (3/3 sub□criteria): 100%
- Category rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - “Traditional, classical liberal arts education ... Latin in grades 3–12 ... history, literature, mathematics, science, fine arts”
 - Trivium elements named: “logic,” “rhetoric,” plus “phonics and grammar”
 - “Utilizing Socratic dialogue and primary sources; ... great conversation of humane learning” (senior humanities thesis; public presentation and defense)
 - “Western tradition is central ... study of American literary, moral, philosophical, political, and historical traditions” (uses “history,” not “social studies”)
 - Summer reading includes Great Books/authors (Dostoevsky, Milton, C. S. Lewis, etc.)
 - “Intentional cultivation of habits that point the student toward wonder and virtue”
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: liberal arts, Trivium, Latin, Great Books/primary texts, Western canon, history (not social studies), wonder .
 - Negative indicators (STEM□first, project□based dominance, social studies replacing history) absent .
- Quantitative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: +12; Negative hits: –0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage (4/4 sub□criteria—Trivium/Liberal Arts, History, Great Books/Conversation, Wonder): 100%
- Category rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - “Socratic dialogue” in upper school; “primary sources”
 - Recitation and memory: daily “opening ceremony ... includes ... student recitations”; “storehouse of memorized Scripture, poetry, speeches, and drama”
 - Rhetoric/oratory: “capstone ... humanities thesis ... public presentation and defense”
 - Cultivation of “wonder and curiosity” as a learning disposition
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: Socratic/dialectic, memorization/recitation, rhetoric/speeches, wonder (restful learning explicitly not named as “scholé,” but the ethos of contemplation is present in aims) .
 - Negative indicators (experiential/project□only, constructivist, student□driven) not present .
- Quantitative keyword analysis

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- Positive hits: +5; Negative hits: –0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage: 80% (4/5: Socratic, memory/recitation, wonder, rhetoric; “scholé/restful” not explicitly stated)
 - Category rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - Faculty “view themselves as stewards of the Christian classical tradition ... model and lead their students toward intellectual, moral, and civic virtue”
 - Teachers as “spiritual mentors” to students
 - “Highly qualified faculty ...” and ongoing apprenticeship/formation culture through Hillsdale College K–12 programs (faculty/teacher formation context)
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: teachers as models of virtue; mentorship and collegiality/faculty formation culture .
 - Negative indicators (teacher as mere facilitator; value-neutral) not present .
- Quantitative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: +4; Negative hits: –0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage: 75% (3/4: modeling virtue, mentorship, faculty formation culture are present; no explicit “portrait of a teacher” document found)
- Category rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY

- Keyword matches (school materials)
 - “Parents are the primary educators ... staff and faculty partner with parents”
 - Parents’ “principal role in spiritual instruction” affirmed; school provides a “faith-supportive environment” in partnership with parents
 - Welcoming/visitation posture: “We welcome you to tour our school ... observe a classroom lesson, and meet our faculty and staff”
- Crosswalk to Six Elements positive/negative indicators
 - Positive indicators hit: partnership with families; community hospitality; formation of affections in concert with the home .
 - Negative indicators (minimal parental involvement, parent as consumer only) not present .
- Quantitative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: +4; Negative hits: –0
 - Estimated percent_positive: 100%; percent_coverage: 67% (2/3: strong partnership and openness are evident; explicit “parent formation/book groups” not observed)
- Category rating: CLASSICAL

Aggregate Assessment

Overall rating: CLASSICAL

Hillsdale Academy’s website evidences alignment with all six elements of a classical Christian school. It explicitly anchors education in transcendental moral realism and Christian theology with communal liturgical practices; defines education as formation in wisdom and virtue; implements a liberal-arts curriculum with Latin, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, and primary sources; employs Socratic dialogue, recitation/memorization, wonder, and rhetorical capstones; presents faculty as mentors and exemplars; and actively partners with parents as primary educators .

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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